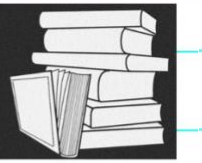
BANNED AND CHALLENGED BOOKS



IN PAST FEW YEARS MORE BOOK BANS & CHALLENGES HAVE HAPPENED THAN IN THE DECADES BEFORE.

MANY OF THE CHALLENGED TITLES ARE COMICS & GRAPHIC NOVELS INCLUDING...

01 *Maus* by Art Spiegelman
02 *New Kid* by Jerry Craft
03 *Genderqueer* by Maia Kobabe
04 *Drama* by Raina Telgemeier
05 *Flamer* by Mike Curato

WHY ARE BOOKS CHALLENGED?

BOOKS FOR YOUNGER READERS ARE MORE OFTEN CHALLENGED AS WELL AS TITLES BY BIPOC & QUEER CREATORS, AND/OR TITLES WITH CONTENT PERCEIVED TO 'AGE UNSUITABLE' OR OTHER WISE 'INAPPROPRIATE'

*[*Over the years, titles such as Beloved, Captain Underpants, The Catcher in the Rye, and To Kill a Mockingbird have been banned / challenged for such reasons.]*

BAN = WHEN A BOOK IS REMOVED IN RESPONSE TO A FORMAL OR INFORMAL CHALLENGE.

CHALLENGE = AN ATTEMPT TO REMOVE OR RESTRICT ACCESS TO MATERIALS OR SERVICES BASED UPON THE OBJECTIONS OF A PERSON OR GROUP.

LEARN MORE >>> WWW.ALA.ORG/ADVOCACY/BBOOKS/BOOK-BAN-DATA

WOW, THIS IS A LOT.....WHAT CAN I DO?

STEP #1

DON'T PANIC

STEP #2: BE PREPARED!

HERE'S SOME SUGGESTIONS ON WHAT TO DO BEFORE A CHALLENGE OCCURRS - AND DURING AND AFTER A CHALLENGE HAPPENS

BEFORE A CHALLENGE

- DO YOU HAVE AN UPDATED SELECTION POLICY? DOES IT INCLUDE COMICS & GRAPHIC NOVELS?
- DO YOU HAVE A CHALLENGE POLICY IN PLACE? IF NOT, CREATE ONE ASAP!
- IDENTIFY STAKEHOLDERS - WHO ARE THE DECIDERS ON BOOK CHALLENGES AND WHAT IS THE PROCESS?
- PAY ATTENTION TO BOOKS BEING CHALLENGED - BUILD ADVOCACY & BE PREPARED!

"WHY ARE COMICS OFTEN TARGETED ?"

IMAGES ARE POWERFUL. IN A LOT OF COMIC CHALLENGES, IMAGES ARE TAKEN OUT OF CONTEXT - ESPECIALLY WITH PEOPLE STILL ASSUMING **'ALL COMICS ARE FOR KIDS'**

ALSO, MANY HAVE FORGOTTEN THAT COMICS SPARKED THE LAST MAJOR CENSORSHIP CRISIS IN THE 1950S. A LOT OF MODERN MISPERCEPTIONS ABOUT THE COMICS ARE STILL BASED ON FALSITIES PERPETUATED BY DR. WERTHAM AND HIS BOOK, **SEDUCTION OF THE INNOCENT**

DURING A CHALLENGE

- WHAT ARE REVIEWS OF THE BOOK? IS IT AN AWARD WINNER? DOES IT FILL A COLLECTIONS NEED?
- IS YOUR CHALLENGE PROCESS BEING FOLLOWED?
- WHAT COMMUNITY SUPPORTS ARE AVAILABLE?
- IMPORTANTLY - REPORT THE CHALLENGE TO THE ALA OFFICE OF INTELLECTUAL FREEDOM: WWW.ALA.ORG/TOOLS/CHALLENGESUPPORT/REPORT (ALL REPORTING IS ANNOYMOUS)

AFTER A CHALLENGE

- UPDATE YOUR POLICIES FOR THE FUTURE
- EX. IMPLEMENT A 'COOLING OFF' PERIOD WHERE THE SAME BOOK CANNOT BE CHALLENGED AGAIN FOR # TIME AND/OR BY THE SAME PERSON
- EX. ENSURE YOUR CHALLENGE POLICY IS BASED ON A FULL READING OF THE TEXT - NOT A SINGLE IMAGE OR TWO TAKEN OUT OF CONTEXT
- IMPORTANTLY - LIVE TO LIBRARY ANOTHER DAY. REMEMBER: YOU ARE NOT ALONE IN THIS.

THANK YOU!

To everyone who filled out the GNCRT survey on comic book bans and challenges in 2022-2023 to help us understand what frontline library workers were experiencing with comic bans & challenges - and how we could help!

With a special shout out to our inspirations in crafting this zine:

Be Prepared by Vera Brosgol

The Hitch Hiker's Guide to the Galaxy by Douglas Adams

GNCRT

READ MORE COMICS!

FIGHT CENSORSHIP!

HAVE QUESTIONS? NEED MORE INFO?

CONTACT US!

WWW.ALA.ORG/RT/GNCRT

@LIBCOMIX TWITTER / INSTA

GNCRT

REPORT CHALLENGES!

BE PREPARED

THE GNCRT GUIDE TO ADDRESSING COMIC BOOK BANS AND CHALLENGES

FIGHT CENSORSHIP!

NEED MORE INFO? FULL GNCRT ADDRESSING CHALLENGES TOOLKIT >>>

ZINE CREATED BY THE ADDRESSING CHALLENGES COMMITTEE OF THE GRAPHIC NOVELS & COMICS ROUND TABLE (GNCRT)

ALA American Library Association